The 6:15

TUESDAY · OCTOBER 20, 2026 NO. 26

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Today	Netflix & Tesla report Q3 after the close (NFLX consensus ~$0.82 EPS, ~$12.88bn rev., 12-analyst est.; TSLA ~$0.43 EPS, ~$28.07bn rev., secondary-source). Knicks' regular-season opener, 7p ET, MSG vs. Philadelphia.
Fri 10/23	World Series Game 1, Brewers vs. Rays.
Sat 10/24	Northwestern hosts Rutgers, Ryan Field.
Standing	FOMC Oct. 27-28 (cut odds thin and inconsistent across markets); OPEC+ meets Nov. 1; midterms Nov. 3 (Trump's self-imposed no-new-Iran-strikes deadline).

No frontier-AI release, rocket launch or VC mega-round verified this run — fifth straight issue skipping this sub-bullet rather than padding it (a Gemini "Argon" claim and a GPT-6 "Astra" claim both surfaced but conflict across sources and neither is confirmed on an official blog). Dec. 11 funding thread stays retired per issue No. 25.

METRICS — ~6:10A ET UNLESS NOTED; NO ICE/NYMEX SETTLE YET PRE-NY-OPEN

Oil	Brent $111.24 (+1.54%, Yahoo BZ=F, 6:08a) vs. $111.49 (+2.77%/24h, straits.live, 5:14a) **[feeds diverge, not reconciled]**; WTI $100.64 (+2.13%, Yahoo CL=F Dec. contract, 6:09a) vs. $107.96 (straits.live, same window) **[large divergence, flagged not averaged]**; spread ~$10.6 on the Yahoo pair. Both up sharply from Fri. 10/16, when Brent first touched $110 since May.
Rates/$	2Y 4.77% / 10Y 5.15% / 30Y 5.48% (Treasury.gov, Mon. 10/19 close); DXY 101.82 (-0.16%, 6:09a).
Equities/vol/gold/gas	S&P futures (ES, Dec.) 7,730.50 (-0.05%); Nasdaq 100 futures (NQ, Dec.) 29,617.50 (-0.35%), both 6:09a; VIX 18.67 (+1.25%, ~6:04a); gold (Dec.) $4,130.70 (-0.71%, 6:09a); AAA national retail gas $4.2786/gal today, down from $4.3333 on 10/14

	[falling pump price vs. rising crude — lag, not yet reconciled].
Asia/Europe	Nikkei 225 64,075.42 (-1.30%, close); Hang Seng 23,867.74 (-1.32%, close); Shanghai Composite 3,735.37 (+0.12%, close). Europe mid-session: FTSE 100 10,682.47 (-0.76%), DAX 25,115.80 (-0.81%), CAC 40 7,806.75 (-0.78%), all ~11a-12p local.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	"Effectively closed to commercial traffic," straits.live, Day 233 **[single-sourced framing]**.
Transits	2 on Oct. 11 vs. 85/day pre-crisis baseline (IMF PortWatch, now 9 days stale) — vs. UKMTO's own count of 125 outbound/129 inbound port calls over the 7 days to 10/16 **[different populations, different windows, not reconciled]**.
Strikes	≥12 ships attacked in the week to 10/16 (UKMTO: 1 sank, 2 disabled, 3 damaged/unclear, rest reached port) — most attacks of any month since the war began Feb. 28. Since: Oct. 17 tanker hit by RPG ~78nm NE of Jubail; IRGC claims a 2m-plus-barrel supertanker caught fire after striking a mine on an "unauthorized route," unconfirmed by any maritime authority. Oct. 15: container ship M/V GFS Pride sank under tow after CENTCOM said an IRGC projectile — not a mine, as Iran claimed — struck it.
Dark tankers/control	No dark-tanker count published today; straits.live's closest proxy is 66 AIS-visible vessels holding position in the Strait/Gulf watch box at 09:22 UTC **[a holding-position snapshot, not an evasion count]**. CENTCOM says it and partners control the strait (400 ships, ~100m bbl transited last week; blockade has cost Iran $25bn in oil revenue, $350m in seized crypto financing); IRGC disputes those figures and says the strait is unsafe without coordinating with its own "Strait Authority." Crisis Pressure "extreme," Escalation Forecast "high," both flat 24h and reported only by band, not score, in today's straits.live edition.

Methodology: PortWatch (lagged daily transit count through the strait itself), UKMTO (weekly port-call/attack aggregation over a wider reporting area) and straits.live's AIS watch-box snapshot measure different populations over different windows; never averaged or differenced here. All straits.live figures are single-sourced to that aggregator.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over — eliminated Oct. 7 (continuity).
Knicks	Preseason concluded; regular-season opener tonight, 7p ET at MSG vs. Philadelphia (banner ceremony for the title defense). Brunson (offseason wrist surgery) expected available.
Northwestern	Played at Michigan State Oct. 17; result not verified this run. Last confirmed mark 4-1 entering that game. Hosts Rutgers Oct. 24.

LEAD

OIL, HORMUZ, INFLATION

Brent clears $111 as the Hormuz war turns into direct US-Iran ship combat — and September's CPI shows the first print of what that costs

Brent crude traded at $111.24 as of 6:08a ET this morning (Yahoo BZ=F, +1.54% on the day), with straits.live's feed putting it marginally higher at $111.49 (+2.77% over 24 hours, 5:14a ET) — the two quotes diverging but agreeing on direction. [fact/flag] That extends a break that started Friday, when Brent touched $110 a barrel for the first time since May, per CNBC. [fact] WTI is similarly elevated: Yahoo's CL=F (December contract) shows $100.64 (+2.13%, 6:09a), though straits.live quotes WTI nearly $8 higher in the same window — a gap this brief won't try to split. [fact/flag] The mechanism is a war that has stopped being a chokepoint story and become a running fight over who controls the strait itself. UKMTO confirmed at least 12 ship attacks in the week ending Oct. 16 — more than in any month since the US-Israeli war on Iran began Feb.

28 — of which one vessel sank, two were disabled and three were damaged or had unclear outcomes. [fact] Two of those losses are now dated and attributed: the container ship M/V GFS Pride sank under tow Oct. 15 after CENTCOM said an IRGC projectile, not a mine as Tehran claimed, struck it; and Saturday, Iran's Revolutionary Guard claimed a supertanker carrying more than two million barrels caught fire after hitting a mine on an "unauthorized route," a claim no maritime authority has confirmed. [fact/flag] A separate RPG attack hit a tanker near Jubail, Saudi Arabia on Oct. 17. [fact] UKMTO itself cautions that its count understates reality: most attacked vessels refuse to report to it, and the agency says it is aware of additional incidents from other sources it cannot verify. [fact, UKMTO self-disclosed limitation] Flows have held up better than the attack rate implies — Kpler data cited by CNBC put Hormuz oil shipments at 9.4 million barrels a day for the week to Oct. 14, about 70% of the pre-war average — but one weekend crossing count found this run was far thinner, fewer than 20 commercial vessels transiting over two days, just four on the Sunday. [fact/flag, figures from different windows, not reconciled]

What's new this week is the control dispute itself. CENTCOM commander Adm. Brad Cooper said in a video message Friday that the US and regional partners — not Iran — control the strait, citing 400 ships and roughly 100 million barrels transited in the past week alone, and argued the attack pace reflects IRGC "desperation" as the naval blockade of Iran's southern ports has cost Tehran an estimated $25bn in oil revenue and $350m in seized cryptocurrency financing. [fact, single-sourced to CENTCOM] Iran's IRGC rejects that framing, says the strait is unsafe for any vessel that doesn't coordinate with its own Persian Gulf Strait Authority, and disputes

the US transit numbers as exaggerated — neither side's count is independently verified. [fact/flag] Iran has also expanded its own vessel blacklist to 124 ships — up from 45 when first published in late August, through an intermediate 81, to 124 as of Oct. 16 — threatening detention, confiscation or fines for anyone who transits without coordinating with it; the latest round of 43 additions included seven more Sinokor-linked VLCCs, per Lloyd's List reporting via Seatrade Maritime. [fact, single-sourced] The same reporting counts at least 26 attacks or security incidents around the strait in the first half of October alone. [fact, single-sourced]

Read: the escalation is no longer just a shipping-and-insurance story — it is now showing up in the inflation data that drives Fed policy and, two weeks out, the midterms. September CPI, released Oct. 14 after issue No. 25 went to press, printed hot: headline inflation at 3.7% year-over-year (above the roughly 3.6% consensus) and up from August's 3.4%, with core at 2.6% y/y against a 2.5% forecast. [NEW, fact, BLS] The energy index alone rose 5.2% for the month — gasoline up 9.1% — and accounted for more than half of the headline's monthly gain. [NEW, fact, BLS] That print reflects September's crude, which was still in the $102-106 range; this month's further break above $110 suggests October's CPI, due in mid-November, is tracking hotter still, which cuts against odds for a cut at the Oct. 27-28 FOMC meeting that were already thin and inconsistent across prediction markets. [read] Set against that: AAA's national retail gas average has actually fallen to $4.2786/gal today from $4.3333 on Oct. 14 — a pump-price lag this brief won't assume survives another two weeks of $110-plus crude. [fact/read] Not every analyst reads the crude move as durable: Invezz reports Goldman Sachs is still forecasting Brent near $90 by December despite the

Gulf supply risk, a call that — if right — implies today's price is overshooting the physical disruption rather than tracking it. [fact/flag, single analyst call, unconfirmed against Goldman's own research note] Watch: tonight's Netflix and Tesla earnings for an early read on consumer and ad spend against this inflation backdrop; whether Iran's Oct. 18 conditional offer to reopen the strait within six days of a deal gets any public US response; and whether Washington's stated reluctance to escalate before Nov. 3 — reinforced by a reported post-midterm strike plan that may include a large-munition option, per CNN-sourced reporting that this brief cannot independently confirm — holds through two more weeks of this.

POLITICS

The Nov. 3 midterms are two weeks out, and the polling snapshot — none of it fresher than Oct. 4 — shows Democrats favored on the generic ballot by a wide but source-dependent margin: a CBS News poll cited that day had them at 54%-45%, and RealClearPolitics' average was characterized elsewhere as roughly D+9, though a separate tracker put the average closer to D+5 with at least one poll (YouGov) showing the gap as narrow as 2 points. [fact/flag, no single reconciled average located] Trump's approval sits in the high-30s in the readings found this run (37%-39%), consistently underwater, though none of these is dated past late summer with confidence. [fact/flag, stale] No fresher reporting on specific Senate or House races was located this run, and this brief isn't treating a two-week-old generic-ballot snapshot as a forecast — only as the backdrop against which Washington's Iran-strike timing (Lead, Iran & Hormuz) and its reluctance to move before voters do should be read. [read]

ECONOMICS

September's CPI (detailed in the Lead) was the week's central print: 3.7% headline y/y, 0.6% m/m; core 2.6% y/y, 0.3% m/m — both above consensus, both driven heavily by energy. [NEW, fact, BLS] Thursday's trio also ran hot: September PPI rose 1.3% m/m and 6.3% y/y, both roughly double pre-release consensus (expectations near 0.6% m/m, 5.3% y/y per two secondary sources); core PPI was 5.0% y/y against a ~4.4% forecast. [NEW, fact/flag, secondary-sourced] Retail sales rose 0.8% m/m against a ~0.4% forecast, with gas-station sales up 6.4%; initial jobless claims were 199k. [NEW, fact/flag, secondary-sourced] Fed-cut odds for Oct. 27-28 remain thin; the prediction-market readings found this run range from roughly 15% to 24% depending on venue and carry a hawkish July FOMC vote (9-3 to hold, all three dissents for a hike) as backdrop — treat the spread, not a single number, as the estimate. [fact/flag] The September print's political timing is notable on its own: it landed five weeks before Nov. 3, and Newsweek's framing of it as an "inflation nightmare" for the administration reflects how directly rising gasoline and energy costs are now entering the midterm conversation already covered under Politics above. [read]

BUSINESS

Q3 bank earnings, due in issue No. 25 as estimates, are now reported, with sources disagreeing on specifics. [NEW] BlackRock beat: adjusted EPS $15.93 against a roughly $14.13-14.25 estimate, revenue up 19% to about $7.75bn (vs. ~$7.56bn expected), AUM $15.49tn (+15% y/y) on $205bn of net inflows; one source separately puts GAAP diluted EPS at $10.57, well below the adjusted figure. [fact/flag] Morgan Stanley beat: revenue $20.34bn

(+11.6% y/y) against a ~$19.93bn estimate, non-GAAP EPS $3.03 against ~$2.93 consensus — not independently confirmed against the primary release this run. [fact/flag] Bank of America is murkier: one account has GAAP net profit falling to $6.9bn (from $8.3bn a year ago) with EPS $0.91, another puts adjusted EPS at $1.08 — 2% below consensus — on a $6.5bn profit figure tied to a $1.2bn regulatory fine from the Treasury; the two accounts aren't reconciled here. [fact/flag] Tonight after the close: Netflix (consensus ~$0.82 EPS, ~$12.88bn revenue, +11.9% y/y) and Tesla (~$0.43 EPS, ~$28.07bn revenue), both estimates only as of this writing; Netflix's own Q2 letter had guided to 12% revenue growth and a 33.2% operating margin for the quarter. [fact] Earnings season is broadening fast — one tracker counts roughly 215 companies reporting across this week alone, including Coca-Cola and Lockheed Martin — though this brief isn't carrying unconfirmed day-by-day placements for names outside the banks and tonight's two reports. [fact/flag] Whatever Netflix and Tesla report will land against the same energy-cost backdrop driving September's CPI — both companies carry meaningful logistics and power-cost exposure, though this brief has no company-specific guidance on that link to report this run. [read]

GEOPOLITICS

Beyond the strait itself (Lead, Iran & Hormuz), the broader picture: Trump's Oct. 11 "energy ceasefire" between Russia and Ukraine appears to be holding on the Ukrainian side — Euromaidan Press found no reports of new Ukrainian refinery strikes since that announcement, after Kyiv said it hit 12 Russian refineries in September. [fact, single-sourced tracker] Russia's Deputy PM Alexander Novak claimed a fresh Ukrainian strike on two refineries (Saratov, Ryazan regions) Oct. 14 as evidence the truce isn't being honored; Kyiv's presidential office called that a fabrication and said the actual strikes hit a data center and an unspecified second target. [fact/flag, competing claims, neither independently verified] Ukraine's security service separately claims 160 Russian oil facilities struck since January, 20 of them in September-October, cutting Russian refining capacity by a claimed 37% — treat as an interested party's figure. [fact/flag] OPEC+'s Nov. 1 review is the next scheduled output decision, unchanged since its Oct. 4 hold. [fact, continuity] The carrier buildout flagged in issues No. 24-25 — a third US carrier reportedly converging on the region — was not refreshed by any dated reporting this run; this brief is carrying it as unresolved background rather than re-reporting the earlier figure as current. [gap, not filled from memory]

IRAN & HORMUZ

On diplomacy: Iranian FM Abbas Araghchi's conditional offer — reopen the strait within six days if Washington accepts Iran's terms — was reiterated around Oct. 18, per NewsNation, but remains exactly that: conditional, with no US response located this run.

[fact/flag, single-sourced] It tracks the broader seven-day reopening framework Iran first floated in late September via Qatar, which called for the US to begin easing its port blockade and halting Hormuz-linked military operations in exchange. [fact, continuity] On the military side, Iran's acting defense minister, Majid Ibn Reza, said Saturday that Iranian missiles — not US bombs — will decide the war's future, warning of costs to US "reputation, economy, and electoral calculations" if Washington escalates. [NEW, fact] That lands against reporting, sourced to CNN via Israel Hayom and not independently confirmed here, that the Pentagon has mapped a bombing sequence against Iranian nuclear and utility infrastructure intended to launch after the Nov. 3 midterms, potentially including a large-munition option; the same reporting notes doubts among its own sources about whether that weapon can penetrate hardened shielding at the facility in question. [fact/flag, single-sourced via CNN, unconfirmed] Neither statement changes Trump's standing Oct. 8 pledge to hold off new strikes until after Nov. 3. On the insurance and tanker-supply side, the vendors flagged as stale in issue No. 25 — Breakwave's war-risk indications, Signal Ocean's ballaster count, OFAC's Hormuz-payments alert — were not refreshed by any primary source this run and are not re-quoted here; treat that thread as background, not news, until a dated update surfaces.

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	0-0; regular-season opener tonight, 7p ET vs. Philadelphia at MSG — not yet played as of this writing.

Northwestern	Played at Michigan State Oct. 17; result not verified this run. Last confirmed 4-1; hosts Rutgers Oct. 24.

Continuity. Technology is cut for a fifth straight issue — no frontier-AI, rocket-launch or VC-round item cleared verification this run. Politics is condensed to the polling snapshot; no fresh race-level reporting was found. The carrier-buildout thread from issues No. 24-25 was not refreshed this run — a gap, not a resolution. World Series Game 1 (Fri. 10/23, Brewers-Rays) enters the calendar now that both pennants are decided; Yankees/Northwestern transactions otherwise unchanged except as noted above.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Flagged this issue: both Brent/WTI quote pairs (Yahoo vs. straits.live); the IRGC mined-supertanker and mine-vs-projectile claims; CENTCOM's and IRGC's dueling strait-control and transit figures; Iran's 124-ship blacklist count; all generic-ballot and approval figures (no single reconciled average, none dated past early October); PPI/retail-sales/claims consensus figures (secondary-sourced); BlackRock's GAAP-vs-adjusted EPS gap and Bank of America's two competing earnings accounts; the CNN-sourced post-midterm strike-planning report; the Oct. 17 Northwestern-Michigan State result (not located). Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.